

DESIGN CODE NS 03

AXEL

the Axolotl

BLACK + WHITE · WHITE BACKGROUNDS · PROGRESS BOXES

US TERMS · ADVANCED BEGINNER · 2.5-3 HOURS · ABOUT 11.5 CM

WORSTED · 3.5 MM HOOK

NAMED ORIGINAL COLOURWAY

PALE PINK · DARK PINK · FUZZY · DARK PINK · SMOOTH

ABOUT THIS COMPANION FILE

Designed for economical home printing and progress tracking.

Large artwork is omitted; the written directions match the full-colour edition.

Pattern profile

NS 03 is the permanent identity of this pattern. Keep it with every revision, tester note, photograph and support message.

FORMAT US TERMS	SKILL LEVEL ADVANCED BEGINNER	ACTIVE TIME 2.5-3 HOURS	FINISHED SIZE ABOUT 11.5 CM
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Named original colourway

PALE PINK head, body, limbs + tail · about 15 g	DARK PINK · FUZZY six fluffy gills · about 8 g	DARK PINK · SMOOTH tail fin · about 3 g
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Use the written colour names and material roles when selecting yarn; screen and printer appearance varies.

Progress tracking

Every construction-table row begins with a printable [] box. Tick it only after completing the row and confirming the stated count.

Read before making

Read every component and finishing note before beginning. Mark completed rows, confirm the count at each row end, and stop immediately if your count differs. Complete internal eyes, embroidery, knots and joins while the relevant opening remains accessible.

Safety: this PDF does not claim that a finished item meets any toy or consumer-product standard. Follow the full Safety section and obtain every assessment required for the finished item's intended market and use.

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How to use this pattern

Read the complete component before beginning it. Move the marker at the start of every crochet round unless the master says otherwise. Diagrams and illustrations support orientation only; the numbered written directions control construction.

US terms · Advanced beginner · 2.5 - 3 hours — Design Code NS 03

A soft pink axolotl with six fluffy gills, a round head and a shell-edged paddle tail. Head, neck, body and tail are worked as one continuous spiral - no neck seam to sew.

FINISHED SIZE About 11.5 cm (4.5 in) tall seated. About 10 cm (4 in) wide, gill tip to gill tip. 4.3 cm (1.7 in) tail. The head is a near-true sphere at 52 mm wide x 51.6 mm tall.

Safety — read this first

Axel uses two 6 mm plastic safety eyes. If an eye, washer or surrounding stitch fails, it can release a small part: lock the washers firmly from the inside before stuffing, then check each eye and the surrounding fabric by hand. If a post, washer or stitch shifts, do not supply or use the item. The gills, arms, feet and tail fin are all sewn or worked on: sew each seam twice and weave every end in for at least 5 cm, then trim close.

No finished Axel has been shown by Novality Crochet Studio to comply with ASTM F963, EN 71 or another toy-safety regime; do not describe one as “baby-safe” or compliant. Embroidered eyes remove the plastic-eye detachment hazard but do not by themselves establish suitability for any age. Before supply, the finished-item maker or seller must determine all applicable classification, assessment, testing, documentation, labelling and traceability duties for intended and reasonably foreseeable use in every destination market.

Materials

- Main yarn: worsted #4, pale pink, about 15 g. Cotton or acrylic with a smooth matte finish - one 25 g ball covers the whole axolotl.
- Gill yarn: fuzzy / eyelash / fur yarn, dark pink, about 8 g. Essential: smooth worsted will not give fluffy gills, and the gills are the whole look.
- Fin yarn: worsted #4, dark pink, about 3 g, smooth - so the shell edging stays crisp.
- Hook: 3.5 mm (US E/4) for a tight gauge so stuffing cannot show through.
- Eyes: two 6 mm safety eyes (9 mm reads as buggy on this head).
- Also: polyester filling about 8 g; tapestry needle; black and pink embroidery floss; stitch marker.

Gauge & size

Gauge: 36 sc around measures about 52 mm across when stuffed (4.5 mm per stitch, 4.3 mm per round). Wider than 55 mm? Drop to a 3.0 mm hook; under 48 mm? Go up to a 4.0 mm hook.

Abbreviations (US terms)

MR - magic ring · ch - chain
 sc - single crochet · dc - double crochet
 inc - increase (2 sc in one st) · invdec - invisible decrease
 sl st - slip stitch · st(s) - stitch(es)
 FO - fasten off · (n) - stitch count at round end

Worked in a continuous spiral: do not join and do not chain 1 between rounds - just keep going round after round.

Techniques used, in the order you will meet them

1. The magic ring - The body, arms, feet and gills begin with a magic ring. Wrap the yarn once around two fingers, insert the hook, pull up a loop and work the first round into the ring, then pull the tail tight. The surface-worked tail fin does not use a magic ring.
2. Working in a spiral - Do not join and do not chain 1 between rounds - just keep going round after round. Keep a stitch marker in the first stitch of every round and move it up each time; there is no join to count from.
3. The invisible decrease - Insert the hook through the front loops only of the next two stitches, yarn over and pull through both, then yarn over and pull through the remaining two loops. It leaves no ridge, which matters on the head and neck where decreases are visible.
4. Closing through both layers - To close a flat opening, fold the piece flat so the front and back layers lie together, then work one sc through each matched pair of stitches. Axel's 6-stitch tail tip folds into 3 pairs and closes with 3 sc.
5. The shell (scallop) - Work all the stitches of the group into one stitch, then slip stitch into the next stitch to anchor it. The group fans into a cup. Working the dc loosely makes each scallop cup outward instead of lying flat.

Instructions

1. Head, body & tail - one piece, main pink

Worked in a single spiral from the top of the head straight through to the tail tip. Head and body are both 36 stitches around; the neck at Rnd 13 is the only waist. Three straight rounds at the head keep it spherical rather than egg-shaped.

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
[] R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	start at top of head
[] R2	inc in each st around	(12)	-
[] R3	[sc, inc] x 6	(18)	-
[] R4	[2 sc, inc] x 6	(24)	-
[] R5	[3 sc, inc] x 6	(30)	-
[] R6	[4 sc, inc] x 6	(36)	head at full width
[] R7	sc in each st around	(36)	eyes between R7 / R8
[] R8	sc in each st around	(36)	-
[] R9	sc in each st around	(36)	lock eye washers and embroider face now
[] R10	[4 sc, invdec] x 6	(30)	-
[] R11	[3 sc, invdec] x 6	(24)	STUFF HEAD FIRMLY
[] R12	[2 sc, invdec] x 6	(18)	-
[] R13	sc in each st around	(18)	NECK - narrowest point
[] R14	[2 sc, inc] x 6	(24)	body flares out
[] R15	[3 sc, inc] x 6	(30)	-
[] R16	[4 sc, inc] x 6	(36)	body at full width
[] R17	sc in each st around	(36)	arms at R17 - R18
[] R18	sc in each st around	(36)	-

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
[] R19	sc in each st around	(36)	-
[] R20	sc in each st around	(36)	-
[] R21	sc in each st around	(36)	-
[] R22	sc in each st around	(36)	-
[] R23	[4 sc, invdec] x 6	(30)	-
[] R24	[3 sc, invdec] x 6	(24)	FEET attach at R24 - R25
[] R25	[2 sc, invdec] x 6	(18)	stuff body LIGHTLY
[] R26	[sc, invdec] x 6	(12)	-
[] R27	sc in each st around	(12)	tail begins; mark dorsal fin anchor
[] R28	[2 sc, invdec] x 3	(9)	-
[] R29	sc in each st around	(9)	-
[] R30	sc in each st around	(9)	-
[] R31	sc in each st around	(9)	-
[] R32	[sc, invdec] x 3	(6)	light stuffing to here
[] R33	sc in each st around	(6)	-
[] R34	sc in each st around	(6)	-
[] R35	sc in each st around	(6)	-
[] R36	sc in each st around	(6)	taper to tip; tenth fin anchor

Mark the fin path while you crochet: on each of Rnds 27-36, place a scrap-yarn marker through the surface stitch nearest the dorsal (top) centre of the tail. Keep the ten markers in one straight line rather than following the spiral's round start. These marked stitches are existing stitches, not extras; they give the fin ten unambiguous surface anchors.

Finish: fold the last 6 stitches flat so 3 pairs line up (3 front + 3 back), then work 1 sc through each pair - 3 sc in total - to close the tip cleanly. FO and weave the end away from the marked dorsal line so it cannot be mistaken for a fin anchor.

The tail runs R27-R36 - ten rounds, about 43 mm - giving exactly ten marked dorsal surface anchors. Five loose double-crochet scallops form the shell-edged paddle along that marked line.

2. Arms & feet - main pink

Arms and feet are sewn on, not worked into the body - bobbles will not give you rounded limbs.

Arms (make 2)

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
[] R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	-
[] R2	sc in each st around	(6)	-
[] R3	sc in each st around	(6)	-
[] R4	sc in each st around	(6)	-
[] R5	sc in each st around	(6)	-
[] R6	sc in each st around, then FO	(6)	arms finish here

Arms: FO with a long tail, do not stuff. Flatten the open end and sew it closed as you attach, so the arms hang softly.

Feet (make 2)

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
[] R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	-
[] R2	[sc, inc] x 3	(9)	-
[] R3	sc in each st around	(9)	-
[] R4	sc in each st around	(9)	-
[] R5	[sc, invdec] x 3	(6)	feet finish here

Feet: FO, cinch closed with a long tail and stuff lightly - do not flatten them, they are plump little balls; sew the cinched nub toward the body.

3. Gills - fuzzy dark pink (make 6, 3 per side)

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
[] R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	-
[] R2	inc in each st around	(12)	-
[] R3	sc in each st around	(12)	-
[] R4	sc in each st around	(12)	-
[] R5	[sc, invdec] x 4	(8)	open edge sewn to head

Working with fuzzy yarn: you cannot see the stitches. Hold a thin strand of matching smooth yarn together with the fur yarn so you can find the stitches, or count by feel with the hook tip and trust the round count. Small errors are invisible in the finished fluff.

Finish gills: FO with a long tail. The open edge sewn straight to the head disappears in the fluff - simply whip-stitch the 8-st opening flat against the head (or cinch the front loops first if you prefer a rounded lobe). Three fluffy gills fan behind each eye - upper angled up, middle out, lower down.

4. Tail fin - smooth dark pink

With smooth dark pink yarn, join with a sl st at the tip end-closure corner. Working from the tip toward the body along the TEN marked surface anchors from Rnds 36 back to 27:

- Work 5 dc in the next marked anchor, then sl st in the next marked anchor. Repeat from * 5 times (5 scallops). Remove each marker as you use it.

FO after the fifth anchoring sl st and weave in.

Each scallop uses exactly 2 marked surface anchors, so five scallops use all 10 anchors. Do not hunt for an imaginary ridge or work into random side bars: the marked dorsal stitches are the path. Keep the final anchoring sl st close to the body junction.

Work the dc groups loosely so each scallop cups outward. For a fuller paddle, first mark a second straight line of ten underside surface stitches (one per tail round), then work a second identical 5-scallop row there; do not stretch the dorsal row around the tip.

A note on fullness: five shells over ten rounds is meant to ruffle - the cupped, frilly edge is the look, not a mistake. If the scallops seem crowded, work the dc even more loosely, use half a hook size larger for the fin yarn only, or work 4 scallops on a shorter marked path.

Finishing & assembly

Eyes and embroidery: complete them immediately after Rnd 9, before Rnd 10 narrows the head. Place the 6 mm eyes between Rnds 7 and 8, 6 stitches apart and centred on the front; lock both washers from inside. While the 36-stitch opening is clear, embroider the smile and optional pink blush described below, knotting and burying all floss ends inside. Do this before stuffing at Rnd 11. Six stitches spans about 27 mm on the 52 mm head - about half the width. Once locked, check each eye and its surrounding stitches firmly by hand; this workshop check does not replace any prescribed product-safety test.

Smile: immediately after Rnd 9, use black floss to embroider a wide shallow U across Rnds 8-9, centred between the eyes and about 5 stitches wide. Keep it shallow; a deep curve reads as a frown. Knot and bury the floss ends inside.

Blush (optional): also immediately after Rnd 9, embroider two or three short pink stitches directly under each eye, just outside the eye line; knot and bury the floss ends inside. Do not use loose chalk or pastel on an item that may be handled or washed.

Gills: sew 3 lobes to each side of the head, behind the eyes, anchored at about R6 (upper), R7-R8 (middle) and R9 (lower). Angle the top lobe upward, the middle one straight out and the bottom one downward so they fan, then tease the fibres apart with a slicker brush or your fingers.

Arms: sew one arm to each side at R17-R18, about 6 stitches out from the centre front, angled slightly forward.

Feet: sew one foot to each side of the centre front at R24-R25, about 4 stitches out from centre, so Axel sits flat and upright.

Before you sew - lay every component out and check: 1 body, 2 arms, 2 feet, 6 gills, 1 fin. Check each against the pattern before attaching anything.

Troubleshooting

- Head firm, body soft. Stuff the head hard at R11 so it holds a sphere and the eyes stay level. Keep the body light so Axel stays squishy and sits down.
- Neck collapsing. The 18-stitch neck is deliberately narrow. First pack a little more stuffing into the neck through the body opening before closing R25. For a permanently sturdier neck, work R13 as [7 sc, inc] x 2, 2 sc (20), then change R14 to [4 sc, inc] x 4 (24) so it consumes all 20 stitches; R15 onward is unchanged.
- Fin runs out of tail. Five scallops need exactly the 10 marked dorsal anchors from Rnds 27-36. If you omitted markers, identify one surface stitch per tail round before starting; if you shortened the tail, work fewer scallops rather than crowding them.
- Want a wider gill span? As written the gills give about 10 cm tip to tip. Work each gill two rounds longer - add 2 plain rounds at 12 stitches before R5 - for a span of about 12 cm.
- Stuffing shows through. Go down to a 3.0 mm hook. Loose gauge on a 3.5 mm hook is the usual cause.
- Axel will not sit. Move the feet one round lower, keep the body lightly stuffed, and shape the tail behind the body as a counterbalance.

Colourways

PALE PINK head, body, limbs + tail · about 15 g	DARK PINK · FUZZY six fluffy gills · about 8 g	DARK PINK · SMOOTH tail fin · about 3 g
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NAMED ORIGINAL COLOURWAY · PALE PINK · DARK PINK · FUZZY · DARK PINK · SMOOTH.

Colourway notes: Classic pink · White leucistic · Melanoid black · Mint · Lavender

Care

Follow the labels for every yarn and component used, especially the fuzzy gill yarn. Before publishing a care claim or supplying finished Axels, clean and dry a complete sample by the proposed method, then remeasure it and inspect for dye transfer, fibre shedding or matting, stuffing migration, shifted eyes and opened seams. Until that sample test passes, recommend gentle surface cleaning with a damp cloth and drying flat away from heat. Check every eye, gill and limb again after cleaning.

Terms of Use

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Make as many finished axolotl plushies as you like for yourself, gifts, or charity. Sell physical finished items made from this pattern in small batches, in shops, markets and online, provided credit is given to “Novality Crochet Studio”.

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Finish checklist & notes

- [] Every row count checked before moving on
- [] Gauge, dimensions and selected version confirmed
- [] Face and internal ends completed before closure
- [] Components counted and pinned before attachment
- [] Structural seams and hanging points checked twice
- [] All yarn ends, knots and attachments inspected

PROJECT NOTES

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.